

Bathroom Remodel Cost Breakdown: Real Prices for Tile, Vanities, Fixtures & Labor

You've gotten quotes for a bathroom remodel that range from \$8,000 to \$35,000. Same space. Similar materials. How can the difference be that extreme?

Bathroom remodels are a goldmine for contractor padding. There are dozens of specialized tasks—plumbing, tile work, electrical, waterproofing—and most homeowners have no idea what each should cost.

This guide breaks down every component of a bathroom remodel with real market data: material costs, labor rates, and exactly where contractors inflate quotes. You'll know what's fair and what's gouging.

Bathroom Remodel Cost Overview by Scope

Before itemizing costs, here are realistic budgets by project scope:

Scope	Budget Remodel	Mid-Range Remodel	High-End Remodel
Powder Room (20-30 sq ft)	\$3,000-\$6,000	\$6,000-\$12,000	\$12,000-\$25,000+
Small Full Bath (35-50 sq ft)	\$6,000-\$12,000	\$12,000-\$22,000	\$22,000-\$40,000+
Master Bath (75-120 sq ft)	\$12,000-\$22,000	\$22,000-\$45,000	\$45,000-\$100,000+

What defines each tier:

Budget: Prefab shower/tub, stock vanity, vinyl flooring, basic tile, minimal layout changes

Mid-Range: Tile shower with glass door, semi-custom vanity, ceramic/porcelain tile flooring, upgraded fixtures, some layout adjustments

High-End: Custom tile shower with frameless glass, custom vanity, marble/stone flooring, luxury fixtures, significant layout changes

The Itemized Breakdown: Where Your Money Goes

1. Tile Work (15-25% of budget)

Tile is the most visible element in a bathroom and often where costs escalate dramatically.

Floor Tile

Ceramic/Porcelain (Budget-Mid) - Material: \$2-\$8 per square foot - Installation: \$5-\$12 per square foot - Total installed: \$7-\$20 per sq ft - 50 sq ft bathroom: \$350-\$1,000

Natural Stone (Mid-High) - Material: \$5-\$25 per square foot - Installation: \$8-\$18 per square foot - Total installed: \$13-\$43 per sq ft - 50 sq ft bathroom: \$650-\$2,150

Luxury Tile (High-End) - Material: \$15-\$50+ per square foot - Installation: \$12-\$25 per square foot - Total installed: \$27-\$75+ per sq ft - 50 sq ft bathroom: \$1,350-\$3,750+

Shower/Tub Surround Tile

Standard Ceramic (Budget) - Material: \$3-\$10 per square foot - Installation: \$10-\$15 per square foot - Total installed: \$13-\$25 per sq ft - 80 sq ft shower: \$1,040-\$2,000

Designer Subway/Mosaic (Mid-Range) - Material: \$8-\$20 per square foot - Installation: \$12-\$20 per square foot - Total installed: \$20-\$40 per sq ft - 80 sq ft shower: \$1,600-\$3,200

Natural Stone/Marble (High-End) - Material: \$15-\$60 per square foot - Installation: \$15-\$30 per square foot - Total installed: \$30-\$90 per sq ft - 80 sq ft shower: \$2,400-\$7,200

What's included in installation: - Surface preparation - Waterproofing/cement board - Thin-set mortar - Tile cutting and layout - Grout and sealing

Red flags: - Charging \$25+ per sq ft to install basic ceramic tile (standard is \$10-\$15) - Separate charges for waterproofing when it's included in "installed" price - "Prep work" fees exceeding \$500 for standard bathroom

2. Vanity & Countertop (10-20% of budget)

Vanities range from \$200 stock units to \$5,000+ custom pieces.

Stock Vanity (Budget)

Cost: \$200-\$800 (vanity only) - 24-48" width - Particle board or MDF - Basic hardware - Cultured marble top often included

Brands: Home Depot Hampton Bay, Glacier Bay, IKEA

Semi-Custom Vanity (Mid-Range)

Cost: \$800-\$2,500 (vanity only) - 30-60" width - Plywood construction - Soft-close drawers - More finish options

Brands: KraftMaid, Bertch, Thomasville

Custom Vanity (High-End)

Cost: \$2,000-\$6,000+ (vanity only) - Any size - Solid wood construction - Hand-crafted details - Unique finishes

Countertop Materials

Cultured Marble (Budget) - Cost: \$40-\$80 per sq ft installed - 8 sq ft vanity top: \$320-\$640 - Integrated sink, seamless - Can scratch/stain

Quartz (Mid-Range) - Cost: \$60-\$120 per sq ft installed - 8 sq ft vanity top: \$480-\$960 - Non-porous, low maintenance - Modern, consistent appearance

Natural Stone (High-End) - Cost: \$75-\$200 per sq ft installed - 8 sq ft vanity top: \$600-\$1,600 - Unique, luxurious - Requires sealing

Installation Labor

Cost: \$200-\$500 - Remove old vanity - Install new vanity and countertop - Connect plumbing - Level and secure - 2-4 hours

Red flag: Charging \$800 for vanity installation with no plumbing relocation.

3. Shower/Tub (15-30% of budget)

The shower or tub is often the centerpiece—and the most complex component.

Prefab Shower/Tub Combo (Budget)

Cost: \$600-\$1,500 (unit + installation) - Unit: \$300-\$800 - Installation: \$300-\$700 - Acrylic or fiberglass - Easy to install - Limited design options

Alcove Tub Replacement (Budget-Mid)

Cost: \$800-\$2,500 (tub + installation) - Tub: \$300-\$1,200 - Installation: \$500-\$1,300 - Cast iron, acrylic, or fiberglass - Standard sizes (60" x 30") - Surround must be separate

Tile Shower with Fiberglass Base (Mid-Range)

Cost: \$3,000-\$6,000 (complete) - Shower pan: \$300-\$600 - Tile work: \$1,600-\$3,200 - Glass door: \$700-\$1,500 - Fixtures: \$400-\$700 - Custom appearance without full custom cost

Custom Tile Shower (Mid-High)

Cost: \$5,000-\$12,000 (complete) - Tile pan (custom): \$800-\$1,800 - Tile work: \$2,400-\$6,000 - Frameless glass door: \$1,200-\$2,500 - Fixtures: \$600-\$1,700 - Any size, full customization

Luxury Walk-In Shower (High-End)

Cost: \$10,000-\$25,000+ (complete) - Custom pan/curbless: \$1,500-\$3,500 - Premium tile work: \$4,000-\$10,000 - Frameless glass: \$2,000-\$4,000 - Luxury fixtures (body sprays, rain head): \$2,500-\$7,500 - Spa-like features

Freestanding Tub (High-End)

Cost: \$2,500-\$8,000 (tub + installation) - Tub: \$1,500-\$5,000 - Plumbing (floor-mount filler): \$500-\$1,500 - Installation: \$500-\$1,500 - Acrylic, stone, or cast iron - Statement piece

Red flags: - Charging \$2,000 to install a prefab shower (should be \$300-\$700) - "Waterproofing" listed separately when included in tile installation - Glass door quotes 2x higher than retail (Lowe's/Home Depot prices are transparent)

4. Plumbing (15-25% of budget)

Plumbing is where costs explode if you're relocating fixtures.

Fixture Replacement (No Relocation)

Toilet Installation - Cost: \$150-\$400 (labor only) - Remove old toilet - Install new wax ring - Set new toilet - Connect water supply - 1-2 hours

Sink/Faucet Installation - Cost: \$200-\$500 (labor only) - Remove old sink/faucet - Install new fixtures - Connect supply and drain - 2-3 hours

Shower Valve Replacement - Cost: \$300-\$800 (labor only) - Access behind wall (cutting/patching) - Replace valve body - Connect to existing plumbing - Test for leaks - 3-5 hours

Fixture Relocation (Major Cost)

Relocating Toilet - Cost: \$1,500-\$4,000 - Rerouting drain (3" pipe) - Relocating water supply - May require breaking concrete slab - Permits and inspections

Relocating Shower/Tub - Cost: \$2,000-\$6,000 - Drain and supply relocation - Waterproofing new area - Wall framing adjustments - Extensive labor

New Bathroom Addition - Cost: \$3,000-\$10,000 (plumbing rough-in) - Running new supply lines - Installing new drain/vent stacks - Connecting to main sewer - Code compliance and permits

Typical plumber hourly rate: \$75-\$150 per hour (varies by region)

Red flag: Charging \$1,200 to replace a toilet when no relocation is involved. Standard is \$150-\$400.

5. Electrical (5-10% of budget)

Bathrooms require GFCI outlets, proper lighting, and ventilation.

Outlet Installation

Cost: \$100-\$250 per outlet - GFCI required within 6 feet of water - Includes box, outlet, wiring - 1-2 hours per outlet

Vanity Lighting

Cost: \$150-\$400 per fixture (labor only) - Mounting electrical box - Wiring to switch - Installing fixture - 1-2 hours per fixture

Recessed Lighting

Cost: \$150-\$350 per light - Moisture-rated housing required - Cutting ceiling hole - Wiring to switch - 2-3 hours per light

Exhaust Fan Installation

Cost: \$200-\$600 (fan + installation) - Fan: \$50-\$250 - Installation: \$150-\$350 - Ductwork to exterior vent - Electrical connection - Code-required in most areas

Heated Floor Installation (Electrical)

Cost: \$10-\$20 per sq ft (materials + labor) - 50 sq ft bathroom: \$500-\$1,000 - Electric heating mat under tile - Dedicated circuit and thermostat - Installed during tile work

Typical electrician hourly rate: \$75-\$150 per hour

Red flag: Charging \$500 to install a single outlet. Unless significant rewiring is needed, this is padding.

6. Flooring (5-10% of budget)

Bathroom flooring must handle moisture and temperature changes.

Vinyl/LVP (Budget)

Cost: \$3-\$8 per sq ft installed - 50 sq ft bathroom: \$150-\$400 - Waterproof, durable - Easy installation

Ceramic/Porcelain Tile (Mid-Range)

Cost: \$7-\$20 per sq ft installed - 50 sq ft bathroom: \$350-\$1,000 - Highly durable, waterproof - Classic appearance

Natural Stone (High-End)

Cost: \$13-\$40 per sq ft installed - 50 sq ft bathroom: \$650-\$2,000 - Luxurious, unique - Requires sealing

Installation labor typically: \$5-\$12 per sq ft depending on material

Red flag: Charging \$15+ per sq ft to install vinyl flooring. Standard LVP installation is \$3-\$5 per sq ft.

7. Fixtures & Hardware (5-10% of budget)

The small stuff adds up quickly.

Toilets

- Budget (2-piece): \$100-\$300
- Mid-range (1-piece): \$300-\$800
- High-end (wall-mount, bidet): \$800-\$3,000+

Faucets

- Budget: \$50-\$150
- Mid-range: \$150-\$400
- High-end: \$400-\$1,500+

Showerheads

- Budget: \$20-\$75
- Mid-range (rain head): \$75-\$300
- High-end (body sprays, digital): \$300-\$2,500+

Towel Bars, Toilet Paper Holder, Robe Hooks

- Budget set: \$30-\$100
- Mid-range set: \$100-\$300

- High-end set: \$300-\$1,000+

Mirrors & Medicine Cabinets

- Budget: \$50-\$200
- Mid-range: \$200-\$600
- High-end (custom, LED-lit): \$600-\$2,500+

Red flag: Contractor charging \$200 to install a towel bar. Standard installation is \$30-\$75.

8. Labor (20-30% of budget)

Beyond specialized trades, general contractor labor includes:

Demolition

Cost: \$500-\$1,500 - Remove old fixtures, tile, flooring - Haul away debris - Dumpster rental:
\$200-\$400 - 1-2 days

Drywall Repair & Painting

Cost: \$800-\$2,000 - Patching walls after demo - Skim coating - Moisture-resistant paint (2 coats) - 2-3 days

General Carpentry

Cost: \$50-\$100 per hour - Framing adjustments - Installing trim/molding - Hanging doors - Miscellaneous adjustments

Red flag: "Labor" line items without task-specific breakdown. Insist on details.

Small vs. Medium vs. Large Bathroom Budgets

Powder Room Remodel (20-30 sq ft)

Budget (\$3,000-\$6,000): - Toilet replacement: \$300-\$600 - Stock vanity (24"): \$400-\$800 - Vinyl flooring: \$150-\$300 - Basic mirror/lighting: \$150-\$400 - Paint: \$200-\$400 - Labor (demo, install, paint): \$1,200-\$2,500 - Permits/contingency: \$600-\$1,000

Mid-range (\$6,000-\$12,000): - Upgraded toilet: \$500-\$1,000 - Semi-custom vanity: \$800-\$1,800 - Tile flooring: \$300-\$700 - Designer mirror/lighting: \$400-\$1,000 - Custom paint/wallpaper: \$400-\$800 - Labor: \$2,500-\$5,000 - Permits/contingency: \$1,100-\$2,700

Small Full Bath Remodel (35-50 sq ft)

Budget (\$6,000-\$12,000): - Prefab tub/shower: \$900-\$1,800 - Toilet: \$300-\$600 - Stock vanity: \$400-\$900 - Vinyl flooring: \$200-\$450 - Basic tile surround: \$800-\$1,500 - Fixtures/hardware: \$300-\$700 - Labor: \$2,500-\$4,500 - Permits/contingency: \$600-\$2,500

Mid-range (\$12,000-\$22,000): - Tile shower with glass door: \$3,500-\$6,500 - Upgraded toilet: \$400-\$900 - Semi-custom vanity: \$1,000-\$2,200 - Tile flooring: \$500-\$1,200 - Designer fixtures: \$600-\$1,400 - Labor: \$4,500-\$7,500 - Permits/contingency: \$1,500-\$4,300

Master Bath Remodel (75-120 sq ft)

Budget (\$12,000-\$22,000): - Prefab shower + tub: \$1,800-\$3,500 - Dual vanity (stock): \$1,000-\$2,200 - Toilet: \$300-\$700 - Vinyl flooring: \$400-\$800 - Basic tile work: \$1,500-\$3,000 - Fixtures/hardware: \$600-\$1,300 - Labor: \$5,000-\$8,500 - Permits/contingency: \$1,400-\$3,000

Mid-range (\$22,000-\$45,000): - Custom tile shower: \$6,000-\$11,000 - Soaking tub: \$1,500-\$3,500 - Dual vanity (semi-custom): \$2,000-\$4,500 - Tile flooring: \$1,200-\$2,500 - Designer fixtures: \$1,500-\$3,500 - Labor: \$8,000-\$15,000 - Permits/contingency: \$2,800-\$7,000

High-end (\$45,000-\$100,000+): - Luxury walk-in shower: \$12,000-\$22,000 - Freestanding tub: \$3,500-\$8,000 - Custom dual vanity: \$4,000-\$10,000 - Marble/stone flooring: \$2,000-\$5,000 - Heated floors: \$1,000-\$2,500 - Premium fixtures: \$3,000-\$8,000 - Extensive layout changes: \$5,000-\$12,000 - Labor: \$15,000-\$30,000 - Permits/contingency: \$9,500-\$25,000

Where Contractors Pad Bathroom Quotes

Based on thousands of quote analyses, here's where padding is most common:

1. Tile Installation Labor

The scam: Quoting \$25-\$35 per sq ft for basic ceramic tile installation.

Reality: Standard ceramic tile installation is \$10-\$15 per sq ft, including prep and waterproofing.

How to catch it: Ask for per-square-foot breakdown and compare to industry standards.

2. Separate "Waterproofing" Charges

The scam: Adding \$800-\$1,500 for waterproofing when it's already included in tile installation.

Reality: Waterproofing (cement board, RedGard, etc.) is part of standard tile prep.

How to catch it: If waterproofing is listed separately, verify what's included in tile labor.

3. Glass Door Markups

The scam: Charging \$2,500 for a frameless glass door that retails for \$1,200.

Reality: Reasonable markup is 20-40%. You can verify door prices online (Home Depot, Lowe's, specialty shops).

How to catch it: Research the specific door model and compare prices.

4. Plumbing "Surprises"

The scam: Discovering "hidden issues" after demo that require \$2,000-\$5,000 in additional plumbing work.

Reality: Some issues are legitimate, but experienced contractors should identify most problems upfront.

How to catch it: Include a clause in your contract requiring written approval before additional work exceeding \$500.

5. Vague "Prep Work" Fees

The scam: \$1,200 "prep work" charge with no itemization.

Reality: Prep is included in tile installation, or should be itemized (demo, cement board, etc.).

How to catch it: Demand task-specific breakdown for any "prep" or "miscellaneous" charges.

6. Permit Padding

The scam: Charging \$800 for permits that cost \$200.

Reality: Bathroom permits typically cost \$100-\$400 depending on municipality.

How to catch it: Call your local building department and verify permit costs.

Money-Saving Tips Without Sacrificing Quality

1. Keep the Layout

Moving plumbing is the single biggest cost driver. If you can work with your existing layout, you'll save \$3,000-\$8,000.

2. Choose Prefab Where It Doesn't Show

A prefab shower base under beautiful tile looks identical to a custom pan—and saves \$500-\$1,200.

3. Buy Fixtures Yourself

Contractors mark up toilets, faucets, and lighting 30-50%. Buy during sales and save \$500-\$2,000.

4. Do Your Own Demo

Bathroom demo is labor-intensive but not technically difficult. Doing it yourself saves \$500-\$1,200.

What you'll need: - Basic tools (pry bar, hammer, utility knife, screwdriver) - Safety gear (gloves, goggles, respirator) - Dumpster rental (\$200-\$400) - 1-2 days of hard work

5. Tile Only Where It Matters

Full-wall tile in the shower is beautiful, but tiling to 6 feet instead of ceiling height saves \$400-\$1,000 in materials and labor.

6. Choose Porcelain Over Natural Stone

Modern porcelain tile mimics marble and stone beautifully—at 40-60% less cost and with no sealing required.

7. Refinish Instead of Replace

If your tub is structurally sound, professional refinishing costs \$400-\$600 vs. \$800-\$2,500 for replacement.

8. Skip Heated Floors

They're luxurious but add \$500-\$1,500. A heated towel rack delivers warmth for \$200-\$400.

9. Use Semi-Custom Vanities

Semi-custom vanities look nearly identical to custom and cost 40-60% less.

10. Get Three Quotes

This is non-negotiable. Three quotes from licensed, insured contractors will show you the fair market range.

Timeline Expectations

Understanding realistic timelines helps you spot padding or overbooked contractors.

Powder Room

Timeline: 1-2 weeks - Days 1-2: Demo - Days 3-5: Plumbing, electrical, drywall - Days 6-8: Tile work - Days 9-10: Fixtures, paint, final touches

Small Full Bath

Timeline: 2-3 weeks - Week 1: Demo, rough plumbing/electrical - Week 2: Tile work (floor and shower) - Week 3: Fixtures, vanity, paint, completion

Master Bath

Timeline: 3-5 weeks - Week 1: Demo and rough work - Week 2-3: Tile work (extensive) - Week 4: Fixtures, vanity, custom elements - Week 5: Final touches, punch list

Red flag: If a contractor says a powder room will take 8 weeks, they're overbooked or padding the timeline.

Verify Your Bathroom Remodel Quote

Analyzing a multi-page quote with dozens of specialized line items is overwhelming. That's why we built Ungouge.ai.

How it works: 1. Upload your bathroom remodel quote - PDF, photo, email—any format 2. Our AI analyzes every line item - Materials, labor rates, markups compared to real market data 3. Get a detailed breakdown - See what's fair, what's high, and where you're being overcharged 4. No email, no sales pitch - Just the truth about your quote

Try it now: ungouge.ai

Final Thoughts: Renovate Smart, Not Blind

A bathroom remodel delivers excellent ROI—if you're not overpaying by 30-50%.

You now know: - What each component should cost - Where contractors pad quotes - How to save money without cutting quality - What timeline is realistic

Get multiple quotes. Ask questions. Verify costs. Don't let complexity be a smokescreen for overcharging.

Your bathroom. Your money. Your decision.

Know your numbers. Remodel with confidence.